

How can I trim space in XSLT without replacing repating whitespaces by single ones?

How can I trim space in XSLT without replacing repating whitespaces by single ones? - Author not stated, Stack Overflow.

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The function `normalize-space` replaces sequences of whitespaces by a single space and trims the provided string. How can I only trim the string without the replacement of whitespaces? There are proprietary solutions like `orcl:left-trim`, but I am looking for a non-proprietary one.

Example:

```
<xsl:value-of select="trim(/Car/Description)"/>
```

should turn

```
<car>
  <description> To get more information look at:      www.example.com </description>
</car>
```

into

"To get more information look at: www.example.com"

- [xml](#)
- [xslt](#)
- [xpath](#)

asked Dec 20, 2012 at 14:24

[

[\[image: Mathias Bader's user avatar\]](#)

](<https://stackoverflow.com/users/1508529/mathias-bader>)

[Mathias Bader](#)

3,9648 gold badges43 silver badges67 bronze badges

[]() []()

17

A solution using just xslt 1.0 templates:

```

<xsl:variable name="whitespace" select=""

'' />

<!-- Strips trailing whitespace characters from 'string' -->
<xsl:template name="string-rtrim">
  <xsl:param name="string" />
  <xsl:param name="trim" select="$whitespace" />

  <xsl:variable name="length" select="string-length($string)" />

  <xsl:if test="$length > 0">
    <xsl:choose>
      <xsl:when test="contains($trim, substring($string, $length, 1))">
        <xsl:call-template name="string-rtrim">
          <xsl:with-param name="string" select="substring($string, 1, $length -
1)" />

          <xsl:with-param name="trim" select="$trim" />
        </xsl:call-template>
      </xsl:when>
      <xsl:otherwise>
        <xsl:value-of select="$string" />
      </xsl:otherwise>
    </xsl:choose>
  </xsl:if>
</xsl:template>

<!-- Strips leading whitespace characters from 'string' -->
<xsl:template name="string-ltrim">
  <xsl:param name="string" />
  <xsl:param name="trim" select="$whitespace" />

  <xsl:if test="string-length($string) > 0">
    <xsl:choose>
      <xsl:when test="contains($trim, substring($string, 1, 1))">
        <xsl:call-template name="string-ltrim">
          <xsl:with-param name="string" select="substring($string, 2)" />
          <xsl:with-param name="trim" select="$trim" />
        </xsl:call-template>
      </xsl:when>
      <xsl:otherwise>
        <xsl:value-of select="$string" />
      </xsl:otherwise>
    </xsl:choose>
  </xsl:if>
</xsl:template>

```

```

    </xsl:if>
</xsl:template>

<!-- Strips leading and trailing whitespace characters from 'string' -->
<xsl:template name="string-trim">
  <xsl:param name="string" />
  <xsl:param name="trim" select="$whitespace" />
  <xsl:call-template name="string-rtrim">
    <xsl:with-param name="string">
      <xsl:call-template name="string-ltrim">
        <xsl:with-param name="string" select="$string" />
        <xsl:with-param name="trim" select="$trim" />
      </xsl:call-template>
    </xsl:with-param>
    <xsl:with-param name="trim" select="$trim" />
  </xsl:call-template>
</xsl:template>

```

Test code:

```

<ltrim>
  <xsl:call-template name="string-ltrim">
    <xsl:with-param name="string" select=""
  test  '' />
  </xsl:call-template>
</ltrim>
<rtrim>
  <xsl:call-template name="string-rtrim">
    <xsl:with-param name="string" select=""
  test
  '' />
  </xsl:call-template>
</rtrim>
<trim>
  <xsl:call-template name="string-trim">
    <xsl:with-param name="string" select=""
  test
  '' />
  </xsl:call-template>
</trim>

```

Output:

```
<test>
  <ltrim>test  </ltrim>
  <rtrim>
    test</rtrim>
  <trim>test</trim>
</test>
```

answered Dec 20, 2012 at 14:49

[

[\[image: Jörn Horstmann's user avatar\]](#)

](<https://stackoverflow.com/users/139595/j%c3%b6rn-horstmann>)

[Jörn Horstmann](#)

34.2k11 gold badges78 silver badges122 bronze badges

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Mathias Bader

I like the clean solution of not having to add additional libraries - thank you for this one! Since I would have to ask the project manager first, whether we can add additional libraries, this solution is clearly preferable for me. I guess there is no way to simply put a parameter at the beginning of the xsl-file to have all fields beeing trimmed, is there? I found `<xsl:strip-space>`, but this is only applied *after* the other transformations like `concat(...)`, leading to results like `Lastname , Firstname` instead of `Lastname, Firstname`. It looks like there is no such simple solution ...

2012-12-20T15:35:33.973Z+00:00

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Reply

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Jörn Horstmann

@MathiasBader: `xsl:strip-space` operates on the source document, before any transformations, and removes text nodes which only contain whitespace. It probably won't solve your problem. The easiest solution would probably to create a separate transformation that only trims whitespace of selected elements, and use its result as input for the second transformation. This can be done in a single stylesheet using extension functions for a specific processor, or using an external tool/api to invoke the transformations.

2012-12-20T16:17:08.357Z+00:00

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Reply

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Mathias Bader

Using a separate (pre-)transformation by an external tool was something that I also had in mind. I just thought that the problem seems to be that common, that I thought there must be an easier solution provided by XSLT that I just didn't find yet.

2012-12-20T17:14:02.987Z+00:00

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Reply

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`normalize-space(actualSting)` - This will do it.

answered Nov 2, 2014 at 7:11

[

[\[image: softarchsolutions's user avatar\]](#)

](<https://stackoverflow.com/users/3239370/softarchsolutions>)

[softarchsolutions](#)

1292 silver badges1 bronze badge

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Mathias Bader

This would also remove repeating whitespaces in the middle. I was looking for a solution that doesn't do that.

2014-11-03T13:36:39.297Z+00:00

3

Reply

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4

A very short solution with XSLT1:

```

<xsl:template name="trim">
  <xsl:param name="str"/>

  <xsl:choose>
    <xsl:when test="string-length($str) > 0 and substring($str, 1, 1) = ' '>
      <xsl:call-template name="trim"><xsl:with-param name="str"><xsl:value-
of select="substring($str, 2)"/></xsl:with-param></xsl:call-template></xsl:when>
      <xsl:when test="string-length($str) > 0 and substring($str, string-
length($str)) = ' '>
        <xsl:call-template name="trim"><xsl:with-param name="str"><xsl:value-
of select="substring($str, 1, string-length($str)-1)"/></xsl:with-param></xsl:call-
template></xsl:when>
      <xsl:otherwise><xsl:value-of select="$str"/></xsl:otherwise>
    </xsl:choose>
  </xsl:template>

```

answered May 26, 2015 at 15:46

[

[\[image: Nik Developer's user avatar\]](#)

](<https://stackoverflow.com/users/2102103/nik-developer>)

[Nik Developer](#)

838 bronze badges

Comments

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4

Using **FXSL** (open source library for XSLT functional programming, written entirely in XSLT) one simply writes:

```

<xsl:stylesheet version="1.0" xmlns:xsl="http://www.w3.org/1999/XSL/Transform">
  <xsl:import href="trim.xsl"/>

  <xsl:output method="text"/>
  <xsl:template match="*/description">
    '<xsl:call-template name="trim">
      <xsl:with-param name="pStr" select="."/>
    </xsl:call-template>'
  </xsl:template>
</xsl:stylesheet>

```

When this transformation is applied on the provided XML document:

```
<car>
  <description> To get more information look at:      www.example.com </description>
</car>
```

the wanted, correct result is produced:

```
'To get more information look at:      www.example.com'
```

How does the `trim` template work?

It trims the left leading whitespace, then it reverses the resulting string and trims its leading whitespace, then it finally reverses the resulting string.

II. XPath 2.0 solution:

Use:

```
replace(replace(/*/description, '^\\s*(.+?)\\s*$', '$1'), '^ .*$', '')
```

Here is an XSLT - 2.0 - based verification:

```
<xsl:stylesheet version="2.0"   xmlns:xsl="http://www.w3.org/1999/XSL/Transform">
  <xsl:output omit-xml-declaration="yes" indent="yes"/>

  <xsl:template match="/">
    "<xsl:sequence
      select="replace(replace(/*/description, '^\\s*(.+?)\\s*$', '$1'), '^ .*$', '')"/>"
  </xsl:template>
</xsl:stylesheet>
```

When this transformation is applied on the provided XML document (above), the XPath expression is evaluated and the result of this evaluation is copied to the output:

```
"To get more information look at:      www.example.com"
```

edited Oct 15, 2016 at 22:36

answered Dec 20, 2012 at 14:39

[

[image: Dimitre Novatchev's user avatar]

](https://stackoverflow.com/users/36305/dimitre-novatchev)

Dimitre Novatchev

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5 Comments

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Mathias Bader

Thank you for your answer, that sounds like a good solution. Am I right that there is no 'native' solution which wouldn't require an additional library (which, of course, would be preferable to import an additional library)?

2012-12-20T15:27:06.967Z+00:00

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Reply

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Dimitre Novatchev

@MathiasBader, First of all, using FXSL *is* a native solution -- FXSL is a set of XSLT templates. In case you don't want to use FXSL, one can write a recursive XSLT solution -- it just is not wise to do so when one can just call the already existing (and tested) FXSL solution. If you don't want to save a few hours, or one day of additional work, and to be sure there are no bugs in the solution, then write a transformation from scratch. The purpose of FXSL is exactly to minimize the effort of writing solutions to the problems that are very difficult or "almost impossible".

2012-12-20T16:50:11.273Z+00:00

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Reply

[image:]

Dimitre Novatchev

@MathiasBader, To put it in other words, with this answer I want: 1. To save you a lot of time and development/verification effort. 2. To let you know that a tool exists that can dramatically decrease your XSLT development time for most tasks and make tasks that are prohibitively difficult ("almost impossible") quite natural and straightforward with XSLT.

2012-12-20T17:07:19.587Z+00:00

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Reply

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yas

The trim regex doesn't seem to work on a whitespace only string - the assumption being that `' '` is the result of trimming a whitespace only string . This alternative seems to work for me `replace(replace($pStr, '^\\s\\s*', ''), '\\s\\s*$', '')`

2016-10-10T14:36:56.483Z+00:00

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Reply

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Dimitre Novatchev

@dave, Good catch -- thanks! I edited the answer with a RegEx that produces the correct result both in the "regular" case and in the case of a white-space-only string.

2016-10-15T20:44:04.16Z+00:00

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-2

If you don't have any spaces in the middle, you can simply use:

```
translate(/Car/Description, ' ', '')
```

answered Aug 27, 2014 at 18:46

[

[\[image: toddmo's user avatar\]](#)

](https://stackoverflow.com/users/1045881/toddmo)

[toddmo](#)

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Mathias Bader

Nice idea, but as you might have guessed already, that is unfortunately too much of a simplification.

2014-09-03T18:56:57.77Z+00:00

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